

non-Hausdorffness

This is a short blog to explain and construct a non-Hausdorff spaces to someone with no university background in mathematics. In one sentence

A non-Hausdorff space is a space where points can be infinitely close to each other without being the same point

Hausdorffness is a concept that is usually introduced in a class in topology and relies on many little ideas that naturally show the necessity for defining Hausdorffness. These ideas are presented here with as little mathematical build-up as possible, but as a consequence it is likely the reader will have to spend some time digesting the concepts.

In this blog, there shall be some apocrypha's for the sake of not overloading on technicalities, and these shall be sorted in an extra section for those with the appropriate topological background.

1 Build up

The numbers that can be laid out on a single line, one after another, are called the *real numbers*, and the line they form is the *real number line*, denoted $\mathbb{R}$. It is often drawn as:

$$\mathbb{R} \quad \cdots \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ -3 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ -2 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ -1 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ 0 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ 1 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ 2 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} | \\ 3 \end{array} \quad \cdots$$

An element of $\mathbb{R}$ is called a *real number* (to distinguish from complex numbers). Let us choose any two real numbers, say 3 and 4. Then they are a distance 1 apart from each other. Any two *distinct* real numbers x, y have some distance, namely $x - y$ or $y - x$ (depending on which number is bigger). If the distance between two real numbers is 0, then they are the same number, since:

$$x - y = 0 \quad \text{then} \quad x = y$$

But there are spaces in which you can have two points that have *zero distance* between them and yet are *distinct*! Felix Hausdorff, in his 1914 *Grundzüge der Mengenlehre*, built the separation condition directly into his definition of a space, so that distinct points could never be inseparable; it was later authors who dropped the requirement and found the weird spaces worth keeping. In his honour, a space in which there can't exist distinct points that have zero distance are called *Hausdorff spaces*, and the weird spaces are called *non-Hausdorff* otherwise. For example the real numbers $\mathbb{R}$ is Hausdorff.

2 What is a Space?

What is meant here by “space”? The first encounter we all have with the notion of “space” is within the world we live in: we consider the “space” of a room, or the routes of a hiking trail the “space” on which we can walk. These two examples of spaces are very different from each other (in a room,

we have 3 directions, while for hiking trails we usually are limited to lines to follow), and there are many more such examples that come up in the sciences (for example, we consider all possible outputs of an experiment the “total space” of outcomes). This generality of the notion of space has lead mathematics to define the notion of *topology* which is a vast generalization of the Cartesian plane. Going through the technicalities of defining a topology would distract from the specific goal of constructing a non-Hausdorff space. In fact, defining spaces in higher than 1 dimension would increase the technicalities, and so we shall stick to one dimension. Thus, for our purposes, we shall define a (1-dimensional) space as:

A space is a set that:

- *contains numbers and*
- *possibly contains sets of numbers*

This is very abstract, so let us immediately justify this definition. Let us start by being precise what we mean by *set*. A set is simply the way mathematicians group things, for example here are two different sets, one containing the numbers 1, 2, 3 and the other the numbers 3, 4, 5:

$$\{1, 2, 3\} \quad \text{and} \quad \{3, 4, 5\}$$

where we used the $\{, \}$ notation to enclose the elements we are considering. Sets can hold objects other than numbers, for an arbitrary example a set can contain all the words in the English dictionary:

$$S = \{\dots, \text{Hamiltonian}, \text{characteristic}, \text{Hypothesis}, \dots\}$$

A set can also contain other sets (think by analogy a warehouse that has boxes containing stuff):

$$W = \{\{\text{Alice in Wonderland}, \text{Introduction to Analysis}\}, \{\text{spoon}, \text{fork}, \text{knife}\}\}$$

A space will be a set that contains numbers and potentially sets of numbers

$$R = \{1, 2, \{3, 4\}\}$$

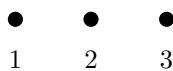
Let us justify why such a set can be thought of as a space. The simplest space is $\mathbb{R}$ which is the set of all numbers and geometrically is thought of as a line. To recover lines of finite length, we can take all the points that lie between two points, for example:

$$[0, 1] = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 0 \leq x \leq 1\}$$

which we can visualize as:



This is an infinite set as it contains all numbers between 0 and 1 (including 0 and 1). We can also take a finite subset, for example $\{1, 2, 3\}$ is three numbers from $\mathbb{R}$ and can be represented as three points:



We can also take all points that lie *strictly* between two points, for example:

$$(0, 1) = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 0 < x < 1\}$$

Notice that 0 is not in $(0, 1)$ because 0 is strictly smaller, $<$, than any point in $(0, 1)$, and similarly for 1. Such examples of spaces fall under the first case of the definition “a set containing numbers”. Let us now justify the 2nd part of the definition: “possibly containing sets of numbers”. The idea is that the numbers should be considered as points, and the sets of numbers should be thought of as being points that are *glued together*.

Principle of Gluing

Let us demonstrate this with an example: the following set splits the even and the odd numbers into two sets:

$$P = \{\{0, 2, 4, 6, \dots\}, \{1, 3, 5, 7, \dots\}\} = \{E, O\}$$

where we labeled the sets within P

- E for even numbers, and
- O for odd numbers

Notice that P only has *two* sets (each set contains infinitely many elements), and hence P only contains 2 points. The way to think about these points is to interpret all the elements within E being “equal” (or glued) to each other and similarly all the elements within O being “equal” (or glued) to each other. In mathematical notation:

$$0 = 2 = 4 = \dots \quad \text{and} \quad 1 = 3 = 5 = \dots \quad \text{but} \quad 0 \neq 1, 4 \neq 7, \text{ etc.}$$

We can think of the two sets of P as *only* remembering the *parity* of each number. It does not care if a number is bigger or smaller or divisible by 5, it only cares if it is even or odd. The equality in the above equation is an *equality of parity*, meaning two numbers are the same if they have the same parity. Using the equal sign “=” is confusing as we already use it to mean two numbers are “exactly equal” not just “equal in parity” (or as a mathematician would say, equal *up to parity*). Let us thus create a new symbol $\sim_P$ and write:

$$0 \sim_P 2 \sim_P 4 \sim_P \dots \quad \text{and} \quad 1 \sim_P 3 \sim_P 5 \sim_P \dots$$

So $a \sim_P b$ is both a and b are even, or both a and b are odd, and otherwise we write $a \not\sim_P b$. Geometrically, we say that we *glued* these points together. If we consider the natural numbers $\{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ as a space, it would be infinitely many points like so:

$$\begin{array}{cccccccccc} \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \bullet & \dots \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 & 5 & 6 & 7 & 8 & 9 & \end{array}$$

Then the set P will represent gluing all the even-numbered points together and gluing all the odd-numbered points together, leaving two points, resulting in two points

$$\begin{array}{cc} \bullet & \bullet \\ E & O \end{array}$$

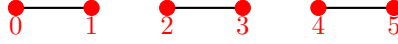
The key take-away is to view $\{0, 2, 4, \dots\}$ and $\{1, 3, 5, \dots\}$ each as single *points*!

Using gluing to form a triangle

Thinking of the above process as gluing is actually how mathematicians construct many objects. To show this is not just a random trick, let us show how we can create a triangle using this method. Say we have three straight lines L_1, L_2, L_3 each of length 1. Let us represent each as:

$$\begin{aligned} L_1 &= [0, 1] = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 0 \leq x \leq 1\} \\ L_2 &= [2, 3] = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 2 \leq x \leq 3\} \\ L_3 &= [4, 5] = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 4 \leq x \leq 5\} \end{aligned}$$

Notice that we are taking x in the real numbers; for example in L_1 all numbers between 0 and 1 (including 0 and 1) are in L_1 (ex. 0.5 and $\pi - 3$ are in L_1). Visually, these three sets represent lines of length 1:



Let us now glue these lines to form a triangle, we want to:

1. glue 1 in L_1 to 2 in L_2 : this is represented by the set $\{1, 2\}$ which is treated as a single point
2. glue 3 in L_2 to 4 in L_3 : this is represented by the set $\{3, 4\}$ which is treated as a single point
3. glue 5 in L_3 to 0 in L_1 : this is represented by the set $\{5, 0\}$ which is treated as a single point

The rest of the points of the lines L_1, L_2, L_3 will be left alone. Let us separate the end-points of the lines so that we may glue them. Let:

$$E_1 = (0, 1) = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 0 < x < 1\}$$

$$E_2 = (2, 3) = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 2 < x < 3\}$$

$$E_3 = (4, 5) = \{x \text{ in } \mathbb{R} \text{ such that } 4 < x < 5\}$$

Notice the strict inequalities now (i.e. $<$ instead of $\leq$). These points represent the edges of the triangle. To form our triangle T , we need to combine E_1, E_2, E_3 with the sets $\{1, 2\}$, $\{3, 4\}$ and $\{5, 0\}$. A natural first-thought in how to do this would be to write:

$$T = \{E_1, E_2, E_3, \{1, 2\}, \{3, 4\}, \{5, 0\}\}$$

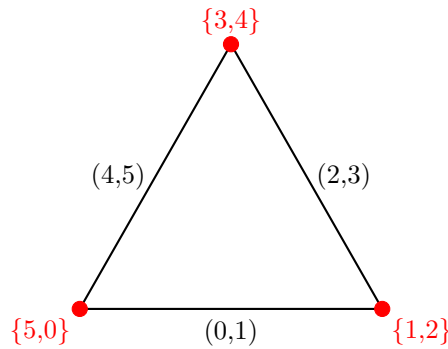
but E_1, E_2, E_3 are sets themselves, and hence the above T only contains 6 elements representing 6 points. We shall need to be a little more careful with how we form T . To do this, we take the *union* of sets. The union of sets is represented by $\cup$ and is written as:

$$A \cup B = \{\text{take all } a \text{ in } A \text{ and all } b \text{ in } B\}$$

In other words, $A \cup B$ is a new set that containing all the elements of A and B . Using the union, we can define our triangle:

$$T = (0, 1) \cup \{\{1, 2\}\} \cup (2, 3) \cup \{\{3, 4\}\} \cup (4, 5) \cup \{\{5, 0\}\}$$

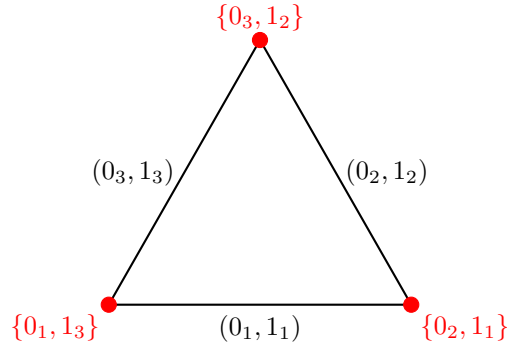
Let us break this down. T contains each element inside $(0, 1)$, $(2, 3)$ and $(4, 5)$ where each element represent a distinct point. T also contains each element inside the three sets $\{\{1, 2\}\}$, $\{\{3, 4\}\}$, $\{\{5, 0\}\}$. Each of these sets contains only a single element: they contain the sets $\{1, 2\}$, $\{3, 4\}$, $\{5, 0\}$ respectively. These are the glued vertices. We can visualize T as:



Giving us our Triangle! Note that instead of taking the intervals $[0, 1]$, $[2, 3]$, $[4, 5]$, we could have taken three copies of $[0, 1]$: $L_1 = [0, 1]$, $L_2 = [0, 1]$, $L_3 = [0, 1]$. The problem doing this is there is no way to distinguish the 0 from L_1 from the 0 of L_2 , or really to distinguish any number from different intervals. To fix this, a subscript is often added so that it is clear which interval a number comes from. For example, 0_2 is in L_2 but 0_2 is not in L_1 nor L_3 . Thus, we can also get a triangle T' by doing:

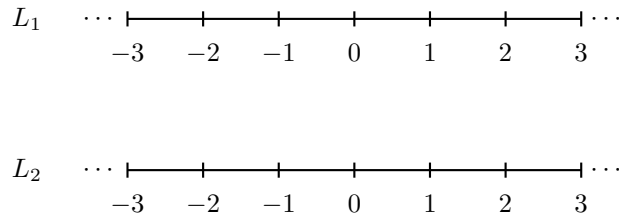
$$T' = (0_1, 1_1) \cup \{\{1_1, 0_2\}\} \cup (0_2, 1_2) \cup \{\{1_2, 0_3\}\} \cup (0_3, 1_3) \cup \{\{1_3, 0_1\}\}$$

Visually:



Non-Hausdorff Space

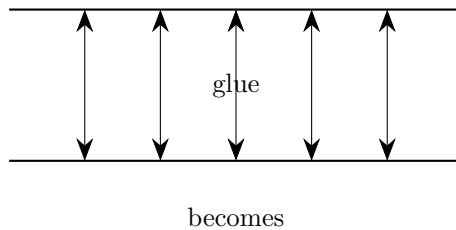
With this, we can finally construct our non-Hausdorff space. Let L_1 and L_2 be two copies of the real number line:



To not get confused with which numbers we are working with, let us label all numbers x in L_1 as x_1 and all numbers x in L_2 as x_2 , for example 3_1 is in L_1 and 3_2 is in L_2 . Let us now pair *all* numbers x_1 in L_1 to the number x_2 in L_2 that has the same value and glue these pairs together, *except* for 0_1 and 0_2 . So take all sets of numbers:

$$\{x_1, x_2\} \text{ (ex. } \{1_1, 1_2\}, \{32_1, 32_2\}, \dots) \text{ but } 0_1, 0_2 \text{ are not in a set}$$

Collecting all these sets together (rather than taking their union, which would just hand back the points), we get a space N (N suggestively for “non-Hausdorff”). Let us interpret N as a space. For any non-zero number, we glued them together:



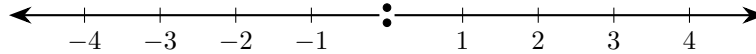
Thus, we don't need to distinguish between the nonzero points in N : we can just say 3 is in N as we glued $\{3_1, 3_2\}$. To be precise, we can label the set $\{3_1, 3_2\}$ as 3, and more generally if $x \neq 0$ we can say x is in N instead of saying $\{x_1, x_2\}$ is in N . As we have not glued the points 0_1 and 0_2 , they remain distinct, so 0_1 and 0_2 are in N .

Now, we can finally ask:

What is the distance between 0_1 and 0_2 ?

Let us say that there *was* some nonzero distance $d > 0$ between these points. Then we can find a nonzero real number t that is between 0_1 and 0_2 and distance $d/2$ from either 0_1 or 0_2 . But that is absurd; there is *no* number between the zero's. Consider the following carefully. The moment we try to move left from 0_1 or 0_2 , we are encountering a negative number that is left from *both* numbers, and if we move right from 0_1 or 0_2 , we are encountering a positive number that is right from *both* numbers, so there can't be a number between 0_1 or 0_2 . This means there is no distance separating them!

The space N is often attempted to be visualized as:



However this is misleading, as it looks like there is a gap between 0_1 and 0_2 , but there is not. It is impossible to visualize this space as we live in a Hausdorff world¹. Nevertheless, this image can be used to ground the intuition that there is no gap between 0_1 and 0_2 ; two points in the middle can be thought of as existing “one atop of another” in the same location.

Any use?

Though this might seem like an exercise in arm-chair mathematising, these spaces do show up naturally in mathematics, especially within number theory and algebraic geometry. It also turns out that there are geometric properties of the world that do not need to consider spaces that are Hausdorff, leading to some interesting intuition about the nature of the idea of what it means to be “close”.

In more practical terms, the idea of non-Hausdorffness exists whenever two processes or things cannot be separated. Take for example the set of all emails at a company. Let's say two emails, `a@email.com` and `b@email.com`, always receive each other's email. Then if you send an email to one email, the other will always get it, making it impossible to separate the contents of the two emails.

Unfortunately, to see why non-Hausdorff show up naturally in mathematics takes a lot of build up, and presenting them without this build-up will look a lot like random ideas stuck together (the reader can checkout the technicalities section to see for themselves). But this is also not too surprising as it took thousands of years before such spaces were found/invented, and then to realise that such spaces have immense practical properties in the 1950s (very recent mathematics!).

3 Technicalities

This section is to address the “white lies” presented above and is for those with some more technical background.

¹At least on the macro scale we live in

In mathematics, the most common general use of the term “space” is defined within the field of *Topology*. A topology $\mathcal{T}$ on a set X is a collection of subsets of X that must contain X itself and $\emptyset$, must be closed under arbitrary union of sets in $\mathcal{T}$ and must be closed under finite intersection. Elements in $\mathcal{T}$ are called *open*, and complements of these elements are called *closed*. A *topological space* or just *space* is a tuple $(X, \mathcal{T})$ where X is the points and $\mathcal{T}$ represents some notion of *locality*. We completely ignored $\mathcal{T}$ when defining space and only worked with defining X , however Hausdorffness is defined not as a condition on X but as a condition on $\mathcal{T}$:

*Given two **distinct** points $x \neq y$ in a topological space $(X, \mathcal{T})$, there exist open sets U_x, U_y containing x and y respectively such that $U_x \cap U_y = \emptyset$*

In other words, a space is Hausdorff if there is some way of “separating” the points. This is because there are multiple different topologies that can be put on a space, some respecting the Hausdorff axiom and others not. In this paper, we always worked with the natural quotient topology induced by the euclidean topology we implicitly were adding to $\mathbb{R}$.

Defining a 1-dimensional space as the set of numbers and subset of numbers is too vague. As the definition currently stands, there are way too many possible subsets of $\mathbb{R}$, and by set-theoretic arguments the current definition would be able to produce $\mathbb{R}^2, \mathbb{R}^3, \dots$. Fixing this is a non-trivial task, as it turns out that there is no universal definition of dimension that works in all contexts. The details can be found in textbooks such as [1].

Furthermore, non-Hausdorff spaces are *not* metrizable, and hence it is not well-defined to say that the *distance* between two points is zero. All details can be found in [1]. This is why the notion of Hausdorffness above eliminates the use of distance by working with open subsets.

The use of gluing to represent non-Hausdorff spaces is well-founded at least in the sense that gluing really does produce them: the space N above is the quotient of the Hausdorff space $\mathbb{R} \sqcup \mathbb{R}$. Munkres gives another example in the exercises to his section on the quotient topology, collapsing $K = \{1/n\}$ to a point inside the Hausdorff space $\mathbb{R}_K$ and obtaining a quotient that is T_1 but not Hausdorff. I do not know whether *every* non-Hausdorff space arises this way; the corresponding statement for metric spaces is false, since the quotients of metric spaces are exactly the sequential spaces.

References

- [1] Nathanael Chwojko-Srawley. *Everything You Need To Know About Topology*. 1st ed. 2022. URL: https://nathanaelsrawley.com/assets/pdfs/notes/EYNTKA_topology.pdf.